



EXERCISE · MODULE 4 OF 7

Map the Journey, Cut the Waste

A hands-on exercise for Value stream focus — trace one feature from a customer's mouth to production, and find out where the time really goes.

20 min work

5 min present

5 min debrief

EXERCISE FLOW

Three phases, thirty minutes

01



Map & Redesign

20 min

Small groups map the current-state value stream, classify every step, and sketch a leaner future state.

02



Present

5 min

Two groups present their future-state map and the lead-time cut they found; rest post their work for a gallery walk.

03



Debrief

5 min

Facilitator connects the patterns back to the core principle and previews Module 5.

THE SCENARIO

Hand each group this current-state map

A customer asks support for “export to PDF.” Here is every step between that request and the feature reaching production.

Step	Touch	Wait
1. Request lands in support ticket queue	0.1d	20d
2. Backlog triage (monthly batch)	0.25d	45d
3. Quarterly roadmap review	0.5d	30d
4. Spec + sign-off from 3 stakeholders	3d	15d
5. Design mockups + review	3d	4d
6. Engineer builds the feature	5d	2d
7. Code review + QA pass	1.5d	8d
8. UAT + Change Advisory Board	0.75d	21d
9. Release train + deploy	0.2d	10d

Totals: 14.3d touch • 155d wait • 169d lead time

WHAT'S HIDDEN

- X No one has ever measured the lead time
- X 169 days to ship one button
- X Only ~8% of that time is actual work
- X Every team swears they're not the bottleneck

YOUR TASK • 20 MIN • GROUPS OF 3–4

Map it, classify it, cut it

Work from the Slide 3 table. Every future-state step you keep must earn its place — be ready to defend it.

1 Do the math

Add up total touch time and total lead time. Calculate the value-add ratio: touch time ÷ lead time.

2 Classify every step

Label each of the 9 steps: value-add (shapes the feature), necessary-but-not-value-add, or pure waste.

3 Redesign the future state

Cut, merge, or shrink steps. Replace batch cadences and queues with flow — keep only what customers or real risk require.

4 Recompute the ratio

What's the new lead time and value-add ratio? What had to be true for that cut to be safe?

FACILITATOR RUN SHEET

How to run the room

0:00

Post the current-state table (Slide 3) and the four prompts (Slide 4). Form groups of 3–4. Start a visible timer.

0:12

Checkpoint: every group should have the VA ratio calculated (~8%) before they start redesigning — nudge groups still debating classification.

0:20

Time's up. Two groups present their future-state map and new ratio, 2–2.5 min apiece. Everyone else posts their map.

0:25

Debrief: name the pattern (Slide 11), tie back to the principle, preview Module 5.

Materials: printed/linked current-state table, shared doc or whiteboard per group, visible countdown timer.



MODEL SOLUTION

What a real value-stream cut looks like

The next four slides walk the same “export to PDF” journey through each prompt, step by step — use them to calibrate groups during share-out, not to hand out in advance.

STEP 1 OF 4 · DO THE MATH

Measure the journey before judging any step

BEFORE

Nobody had ever added it up. Every team felt busy and assumed the delay was someone else's queue.

Touch time: 14.3 days

Lead time: 169 days

AFTER

Value-add ratio = touch time ÷ lead time
= $14.3 \div 169.3$
 $\approx 8\%$

For every 100 days a customer waits, the feature was actually being worked on for about 8 of them.

Why it matters: You can't argue about waste from opinions. One number — 8% — turns a vague “it takes too long” into a shared, undeniable target.

STEP 2 OF 4 · CLASSIFY EVERY STEP

Not all activity is value — and not all delay is waste

BEFORE

Every step was treated as equally necessary. “That’s just how we ship things here” — no one had separated the work customers pay for from the queues around it.

AFTER

Value-add (~9.6d): spec content, design, build, QA verification, deploy.

Necessary non-value-add (~0.75d): the one compliance sign-off a regulator actually requires.

Waste (~159d): triage batching, quarterly cadence, redundant stakeholder loop, review queues, CAB, release train.

Why it matters: “Waste” isn’t an insult to the people doing the step — it’s a label for delay the customer never asked for and no rule requires.

STEP 3 OF 4 · REDESIGN THE FUTURE STATE

Replace batches and queues with flow

BEFORE

9 sequential handoffs, each waiting for the next scheduled meeting: monthly triage, quarterly planning, a 3-person review loop, a monthly CAB, a batched release train.

AFTER

Triage: monthly batch → continuous backlog refinement.

Planning: quarterly → rolling weekly prioritization.

Spec + design: 2 handoffs → one collaborative session.

Review: CAB for everything → automated checklist; CAB only for high-risk changes.

Release: quarterly train → on-demand CI/CD deploy.

Why it matters: Every cut targets a calendar-driven wait, not the work itself — the people and the judgment stay; the batching that forces them to wait for a meeting doesn't.

STEP 4 OF 4 · RECOMPUTE THE RATIO

Prove the redesign, don't just assert it

BEFORE

Lead time: 169 days
Touch time: 14.3 days
Value-add ratio: ~8%

“We're moving as fast as we can” was unfalsifiable — there was no baseline to check it against.

AFTER

Lead time: ~18 days
Touch time: ~13 days (barely changed — the real work was never the problem)
Value-add ratio: ~72%

Same customer request, same engineering effort, 9x faster — because the cuts came from the queues, not the craft.

Why it matters: The goal was never “work faster.” It was removing time the customer's feature spent waiting for nothing to happen.

DEBRIEF • 5 MIN

Three questions to ask of any workflow

1

What's our actual value-add ratio?

Turns “we're slow” into a measured, shared baseline.

2

Which steps exist for the customer, and which for the calendar?

Separates real work from batching and scheduled handoffs.

3

What would have to be true to cut this queue?

Forces a real answer instead of “that's how we've always done it.”

The pattern: speed doesn't come from working harder inside each step — it comes from removing the steps that only exist because of how work is scheduled.



UP NEXT

Module 5: Making flow visible every day

Keep today's future-state map — you'll turn it into a live board that tracks flow, not just tasks, next session.